



GOV. GAVIN NEWSOM greets President Trump and First Lady Melania Trump as they visited L.A. to survey destruction from the Palisades fire. The president arrived after touring hurricane-stricken North Carolina, where he proposed “getting rid of FEMA.”

After criticizing state’s fire response, Trump surveys the damage in L.A.

President greets firefighters and residents in somber tour of the ruins in Pacific Palisades

BY JENNY JARVIE,
IAN JAMES
AND HANNAH FRY

In a somber scene lighted by an orange Los Angeles sunset, President Trump walked through the ruins of Pacific Palisades on Friday, shaking hands with firefighters and speaking to a handful of residents as he

took in the devastation brought by firestorms that swept through L.A. County this month.

Leveled properties and charred trees were visible in the background as the president walked through a burned neighborhood. Firefighters handed the president a white fire helmet adorned with the number 47 on the front and side.

Trump said he was stunned by the devastation and vowed to partner with local officials to help victims. “We have to work together to get this really worked out,” Trump said. “I don’t think you can realize how ... devastating it is until you see it.”

It was his first visit to the area since taking office — and a potentially contested one after his repeated

threats to withhold federal aid to California.

The trip to Los Angeles is part of a broader national disaster recovery tour. Earlier Friday, Trump visited North Carolina to inspect damage after Hurricane Helene ravaged the area in October.

After briefly speaking with Gov. Gavin Newsom on the tarmac at Los Angeles International Airport on

Friday afternoon, Trump and First Lady Melania Trump embarked on their tour of the destruction in Pacific Palisades, surveying neighborhoods by helicopter and foot. Leveled properties and charred trees were visible in the background as the president spoke with fire officials and residents whose homes were destroyed in the [See Trump, A4]

Confusion reigns as path to asylum blocked



MANY ASYLUM SEEKERS are essentially stranded in Tijuana after having traveled long distances and waiting months for interviews with U.S. officials.

Migrants in Mexico are unsure what to do after Trump officials cancel appointments.

BY MELISSA GOMEZ

TIJUANA — Outside the white gates that secure the entry to this Tijuana customs facility, a stepping stone to U.S. soil, migrants sat on a sidewalk in quiet disbelief this week, their futures suddenly feeling much darker and clouded in uncertainty.

Like thousands of others during the last year, they had arrived at the border to meet with U.S. officials for formal asylum interviews, appointments that many

had worked months to schedule. Getting there, for some, had meant crossing the Darién Gap, a dense and treacherous jungle on the border of Colombia and Panama. Others had traversed multiple countries by bus, and yet others had crowded for months into shelters and local hotels hoping for confirmation of an asylum appointment via the mobile app, CBP One, that the Biden administration had used since early 2023 to ease the process of applying for asylum.

Whatever their journey, they arrived this week to find their appointments canceled without notice or fanfare.

On Monday, shortly after President Trump took office, his administration an-

nounced it was disabling CBP One and canceling all asylum appointments. In a separate executive order, he declared migrant crossings [See Migrants, A7]

Rain to offer relief as uncertainty looms

This weekend’s storm is expected to be light, but with risk of debris flows in burned areas.

BY RONG-GONG LIN II,
HANNAH FRY
AND SUMMER LIN

After an epic dry streak that helped fuel devastating fires, Southern California this weekend will get its first real rain of the winter.

Any moisture will help with the region’s parched, combustible landscape. Yet there is concern that the upcoming rain may provide only temporary relief. After this weekend, a dry spell

Palisades water scarcity was years in the making

Improvements to the system were stymied long before the fire disaster, records show.

BY CONNOR SHEETS

Los Angeles County officials missed dozens of opportunities for water infrastructure improvements that experts say probably would have enabled firefighters to save more homes during the Palisades fire, public records show.

As crews battled the blaze, attempting to extinguish flames that burned huge swaths of L.A. County and killed at least 11 people, some hydrants ran dry.

The lack of water has been a concern at the city and county levels and has come under scrutiny since the fire broke out Jan. 7. L.A. city officials, for example, have scrambled to explain why the 117-million-gallon Santa Ynez Reservoir was left empty for repairs.

But thousands of pages of state, county and municipal records reviewed by The Times show the disaster was years in the making. Red tape, budget shortfalls and government inaction repeatedly stymied plans for water system improvements in parts of the county like Malibu and Topanga outside the city of L.A. — including some that specifically cited the need to boost firefighting capacity.

Many projects on a list of about three dozen “highest priority” upgrades compiled by county officials in 2013 have yet to break ground in communities devastated by the fires.

The county wrote that the upgrades would achieve “critical goals,” including ensuring the system had enough water to meet “fire flow needs.” The estimated cost was less than \$57 million and construction would have taken about seven years.

Plans to build tanks that [See Disaster, A12]

School turns to remote learning after fire

BY DANIEL MILLER,
JAWEED KALEEM
AND HOWARD BLUME

Fifteen days after fire ripped through Pacific Palisades, destroying his house on Liff Street and reducing a good part of his school to rubble, Jonathan Fuhrman pulled up to the kitchen table of his temporary Brentwood home, logged into his laptop and launched Zoom.

“Here we go again,” said the Palisades Charter High School senior, who spent most of middle school in virtual classes during the COVID-19 pandemic and started out high school wearing a mask and taking weekly coronavirus tests. “I wonder if people will be on camera.”

Fuhrman, 18, was one of thousands of students who found himself grappling with yet another historic disruption [See Pali, A8]



JUAN COTOM-LOPEZ, left, and Jonathan Fuhrman attend classes online after Palisades Charter High School closed because of fire damage. Fuhrman, a senior, lost his house in the Palisades fire and is staying with his father in Brentwood.

Will the Gaza cease-fire last?
There are growing signs the second phase of the fragile truce may never happen. PERSPECTIVES, A2

Public sites face extensive damage
City releases initial cost estimate of the Palisades fire as federal funding is sought. CALIFORNIA, B1

After fire, how to cut property tax
A guide for homeowners seeking to reduce burden and defer payments. CALIFORNIA, B3

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